

Beginner Guide: Cat & Panda

Practice lessons followed by two intermediate animal projects

Read before making or selling

Original written development patterns based on the visual themes in your shop. These instructions have not been physically crocheted or independently tested. They do not reproduce the reference images stitch-for-stitch. Dimensions, yarn use and visual results are provisional.

For maker testing and revision. Do not describe this edition as tested, photo-verified or a guaranteed match to the marketing images. No photographic step-by-step tutorial is included.

Inside this file

Practice rectangle and circle | 03-A Seated striped cat | 03-B Panda with optional cradle

Language: English | Terminology: US crochet | Version: 0.1

Before you begin

How to read this edition

Read the entire project first. Each round starts at the stitch marker; move the marker after every round. Work in a continuous spiral unless the instructions explicitly say to join. A number in brackets is the stitch count after completing the row or round.

Work into both loops unless stated otherwise. A turning ch 1 is not counted as a stitch. In flat rows, ch 1 and turn after each row except the last. Fasten off means cut a sewing tail, pull it through the final loop and tighten.

US sc = UK dc; US hdc = UK htr; US dc = UK tr. All instructions in these books use US names.

Abbreviations

ch: chain; sl st: slip stitch; sc: single crochet; hdc: half double crochet; dc: double crochet; st/sts: stitch/stitches; MR: magic ring; inc: 2 sc into one stitch; dec: single-crochet two stitches together; BLO: back loop only; FLO: front loop only. (2 sc, inc) x 6 consumes 18 stitches and makes 24.

Making the stitches

Chain: yarn over and pull through the loop on your hook. Single crochet: insert hook, yarn over and pull up a loop; yarn over and pull through both loops. Slip stitch: insert hook, yarn over and pull through the stitch and the loop on your hook together.

Half double crochet: yarn over, insert hook, yarn over and pull up a loop; yarn over and pull through all three loops. Double crochet: yarn over, insert hook, pull up a loop; yarn over and pull through two loops, then repeat through the remaining two.

Decrease: insert hook into the next stitch and pull up a loop; insert into the following stitch and pull up a loop; yarn over and pull through all three loops. For an invisible decrease in amigurumi, insert through the front loops of the next two stitches, draw yarn through those two loops, then yarn over and draw through the two loops on the hook.

Magic ring and colour changes

Wrap yarn around two fingers, insert the hook under the ring, pull up the working yarn and ch 1. Work the instructed sc into the ring and pull the tail firmly to close. Secure that tail on the inside. To change colour, complete the last pull-through of the previous stitch with the new colour; weave tails into the wrong side.

Materials and testing

Supplies and provisional scale

For dolls and animals: smooth DK cotton yarn, a 2.5 mm hook as a starting point, polyester stuffing, blunt yarn needle, scissors, stitch marker and embroidery yarn. Use small amounts of accent colours. Reserve approximately 50 g each of the main colours and 10-20 g per accent; these are purchasing allowances, not measured consumption.

Target test gauge: approximately 24 sc and 26 rows per 10 cm in a flat swatch. Make ch 25; sc in second chain and across (24), then work 25 more rows of 24 sc. Measure the centre without stretching. Stuffed fabric must be dense enough that filling is not visible. Use a smaller hook if necessary.

Gauge controls size. At this target, 24 stitches measure about 10 cm; a 48-stitch head has a nominal circumference near 20 cm before stuffing. Finished height must be measured from the first sample, not copied from the reference artwork.

Finishing and handling

Use embroidered eyes and flat stitched details throughout these drafts. Do not add beads, loose bells, wire or sharp supports. These are decorative prototypes, not safety-tested toys. Keep loose yarn and stuffing away from small children.

Stuff gradually, pin pieces in position, and use small whipstitches through both edges. Sew each joint twice, then bury the tail through the stuffing and trim. Test each seam with a gentle pull. Follow the yarn label for washing; test colourfastness first.

What verification means

The stitch sequences have been checked for arithmetic consistency. This does not verify shape, fit, yarn quantity or usability. A crocheter must make every variant, record corrections and photograph the finished sample before a customer edition is released.

Beginner practice before amigurumi

Practice rectangle

Ch 13. Row 1: sc into second ch and every chain (12). Rows 2-12: ch 1, turn, 12 sc. Count every row; place markers in first and last stitches. If edges narrow, a stitch is being missed. If edges widen, an extra stitch is being added.

Practice circle

MR 6; R2 inc x 6 (12); R3 (sc, inc) x 6 (18); R4 (2 sc, inc) x 6 (24). A flat circle is the goal. If it cups, check missed increases. If it ruffles, count and check for extra increases.

Before the animal projects

You should be comfortable counting, increasing, decreasing, changing colour and sewing. The first rectangle is beginner level; the assembled animals are intermediate. Work slowly and record changes on the test sheet.

03-A | Seated striped cat - plan

Pieces

One large head, one pear-shaped body, two front legs, two feet, two triangular ears, one tail and a flat chest patch. Use grey, cream, charcoal, pink and red. This is a simplified seated cat inspired by CYRUS7 and by-cyrus-5; those two images represent one design, not two patterns.

Head and body

Use the doll head table in this file in grey, then add R23: dec x 6 (6); thread through FLO of remaining 6 stitches and close. Use the doll body table in grey, leaving its 12-stitch opening for attachment. Stuff firmly and sew neck to underside of closed head, centred over head R21-R23.

Face patch

Cream MR 6; inc x 6 (12); (sc, inc) x 6 (18); (2 sc, inc) x 6 (24). Fasten off. Sew flat over front of head, centred around R14. Embroider eyes either side near its upper edge, pink triangle nose in centre and a black inverted Y mouth below it. Sew short black whiskers flat to the surface; no loose projecting ends.

Chest patch

Cream ch 7; sc across (6). Rows 2-5: 6 sc. Row 6: dec, 2 sc, dec (4). Row 7: dec x 2 (2). Fasten off. Place broad edge toward neck, pointed end toward belly; sew flat to body front.

Cat head and body tables

Head: grey; add R23 described in plan

Round / row	Instruction	Count
1	6 sc in MR	6
2	inc x 6	12
3	(sc, inc) x 6	18
4	(2 sc, inc) x 6	24
5	(3 sc, inc) x 6	30
6	(4 sc, inc) x 6	36
7	(5 sc, inc) x 6	42
8	(6 sc, inc) x 6	48
9-16	sc in every stitch; 8 rounds	48
17	(6 sc, dec) x 6	42
18	(5 sc, dec) x 6	36
19	(4 sc, dec) x 6	30
20	(3 sc, dec) x 6	24
21	(2 sc, dec) x 6; stuff firmly	18
22	(sc, dec) x 6	12

Cat body

Body: grey

Round / row	Instruction	Count
1	6 sc in MR	6
2	inc x 6	12
3	(sc, inc) x 6	18
4	(2 sc, inc) x 6	24
5	(3 sc, inc) x 6	30
6-10	sc around; 5 rounds	30
11	(3 sc, dec) x 6	24
12-14	sc around; 3 rounds	24
15	(2 sc, dec) x 6	18
16	sc around; stuff	18
17	(sc, dec) x 6	12
18	sc around; leave neck open	12

Stuff through the neck opening, then sew to underside of head. Keep body marker at centre back.

Cat limbs, ears and tail

Front legs - make two

Cream: MR 6; R2 inc x 6 (12); R3-R5 12 sc; R6 (2 sc, dec) x 3 (9). Change to grey; R7-R13 9 sc. Stuff lower half. Flatten and sew closed across the opening. Sew upper ends at body R14, with paws resting below body R4. Embroider two charcoal toe lines on each paw.

Back feet - make two

Cream: MR 6; R2 inc x 6 (12); R3 (sc, inc) x 6 (18); R4-R5 18 sc; R6 (sc, dec) x 6 (12). Stuff, flatten and seam across 6 paired stitches. Attach at left and right of body R3-R5, behind the front paws.

Ears - make two

Grey, worked flat from tip downward: ch 2; Row 1: 2 sc in second ch (2). Row 2: inc in both sts (4). Row 3: inc, 2 sc, inc (6). Row 4: inc, 4 sc, inc (8). Row 5: inc, 6 sc, inc (10). Fasten off. Pink inner triangle: repeat only Rows 1-3; sew centred onto grey. Sew 10-stitch base to head R5-R8, one ear on each side.

Tail

Charcoal MR 6; R2 (sc, inc) x 3 (9). R3-R20: 9 sc. Change to grey for R3-R5, charcoal R6-R7, grey R8-R10, charcoal R11-R12, grey R13-R15, charcoal R16-R17, grey R18-R20. Stuff lightly; leave opening and sew at back body R4-R6. Curve tail by securing its middle to body R10.

Stripes and collar

Embroider 3 short charcoal stripes on each outer cheek and 3 on either side of body. Red ch 36; sl st back along 35 chains. Fit around neck, shorten if needed and sew down around its full length. No bell included. Pin all limbs on a level surface, then adjust placement until the cat sits without tipping.

03-B | Small panda - head and body

Scope and yarn

White and black DK cotton. The seated panda can be made alone or with the decorative cradle on the next page. Both by-cyrus-2 and CYRUS6 are visual references; this pattern is an approximation, not a reproduced photographed sample.

Head

White: R1 MR 6; R2 inc x 6 (12); R3 (sc, inc) x 6 (18); R4 (2 sc, inc) x 6 (24); R5 (3 sc, inc) x 6 (30); R6 (4 sc, inc) x 6 (36). R7-R12: 36 sc. R13 (4 sc, dec) x 6 (30); R14 (3 sc, dec) x 6 (24); R15 (2 sc, dec) x 6 (18); stuff; R16 (sc, dec) x 6 (12). Leave neck open.

Body

White: MR 6; inc x 6 (12); (sc, inc) x 6 (18); (2 sc, inc) x 6 (24). R5-R8: 24 sc. R9: (2 sc, dec) x 6 (18). Change to black: R10-R11 18 sc; R12 (sc, dec) x 6 (12). Stuff and sew 12-to-12 to head.

Eye patches and ears

Patches, make two: black MR 6; R2 inc x 6 (12); fasten off and flatten. Sew at head R8-R11 with about 4 sts between patches. Embroider white eye highlights. Ears, make two: black MR 6; R2 inc x 6 (12); R3 12 sc. Flatten without stuffing and sew lower edge onto head R3-R5. Embroider nose and mouth between patches.

Four paws

Black MR 6; R2 (sc, inc) x 3 (9); R3-R5 9 sc. Stuff tips lightly, flatten opening and sew closed. Attach two at body R9 as arms, two at body R3-R4 as feet. White tail: MR 6, then 6 sc; close and sew to body back R4.

Panda cradle and finishing

Decorative cradle

Brown DK cotton, same hook. Ch 19. Row 1: sc from second chain (18). Rows 2-18: 18 sc. Fasten off. The panel is about 7.5 x 7 cm at target gauge; measure your sample. Fold in half so the two Row 1/Row 18 edges meet; sew the left and right row-end edges together, leaving the top open. Open it into a shallow pocket and sit panda inside. Increase the rectangle in both directions if sample does not fit.

Hanging cords

For each of two cords, ch 61 and sl st back along 60 chains. Secure one cord to each upper side seam. Join upper ends for indoor display only. Stitch panda to the cradle through body base so it does not fall out. No tested load rating; do not hang over a cot or use as a vehicle accessory. Keep cords out of reach of children.

Plain seated alternative with bamboo

Omit cradle and cords. Position feet wider, flatten body base gently and stitch paws in place. Bamboo: green ch 16; sc in second ch and across (15); ch 1, turn, 15 sc; fasten off. Make two leaves: ch 6, then from second chain sl st, sc, hdc, sc, sl st (5). Sew stalk flat to front between paws; stitch leaves to stalk and secure their tips. The panda is not guaranteed to stand; a seated display is intended.

Testing checklist

Check neck firmness, symmetry, seam strength, sitting balance and cradle fit. Record finished dimensions, actual yarn used, hook and adjustments. Take front, side and rear photographs of the real sample.

Samplemaker record and sources

Release gate

Each included design must be made from the written instructions by someone other than the writer. Record every deviation and resolve ambiguities. No sample has been made for this edition.

Record

Pattern ID: _____ Maker/date: _____ Yarn brand/fibre/weight: _____ Hook: _____
Gauge stitches/rows per 10 cm: _____ Finished height/width/depth: _____ Actual
yarn weight per colour: _____

Checks

Count each round; record any mismatch. Confirm colour changes, face position, garment fit, joining instructions and assembly order. Take front, back, side and close-up photographs. Check that the result supports the exact product-page promise. Record the corrected version and date before removing DRAFT labels.

Reference standard

US abbreviation and reading conventions checked against the Craft Yarn Council:

<https://craftyarncouncil.com/standards/crochet-abbreviations> and

<https://www.craftyarncouncil.com/standards/how-to-read-crochet-pattern> (accessed 23 September 2026).

Written pattern instructions here are newly drafted, not copied from those sources.

Artwork is not a test sample

User-supplied shop images informed themes and colours only. Their printed measurements and short instructions were not treated as validated patterns. These PDFs deliberately do not label marketing renders as actual step-by-step photographs.